

Poverty may be the most foundational risk factor for poor health outcomes. Although poverty thresholds are calculated in a variety of ways, many international organizations define poverty thresholds as 50% of the median household income in a given country. Since the United States Census Bureau first began publishing an official U.S. poverty estimate in the 1960s, the percentage of the population living in poverty has fluctuated between roughly 10% and 15%. Extensive research shows a correlation between social stratification and health outcomes, with better outcomes corresponding to higher strata.

Concentration of Poverty

According to U.S. Census Bureau data, roughly 1 in 7 Americans is living in poverty, with almost 14 million residing in "high-poverty" neighborhoods (40% or more of residents below the federally defined poverty threshold), nearly double the amount since 1990. High-poverty neighborhoods also tend to have the highest rates of violent crime, so living in these neighborhoods poses both immediate (eg, physical assault) and long-term health threats, as living in an unsafe neighborhood acts as a chronic environmental stressor.

Poverty and Isolation

Poverty also prevents or limits access to many productive social activities, such as working, buying goods and services, community and political involvement, and engagement with social networks. The most impoverished members of society are often marginalized and may engage with mainstream society very little, if at all.

Transmission of Poverty

Poverty is transmitted across generations; numerous studies have found that individuals born into poverty are more likely to raise their own children in poverty. A longitudinal study of 100 households concluded that transmission of poverty occurs because lower-income parents lack economic resources, social connections, and knowledge about the education system, not because they differ from higher-income parents in wanting to help their children succeed. Experts also suggest that the education system perpetuates income disparities; schools in high-income neighborhoods have the most funding, best teachers, and highest graduation rates, whereas schools in low-income neighborhoods face numerous obstacles to obtaining supplies, retaining qualified teachers, and preventing student attrition.

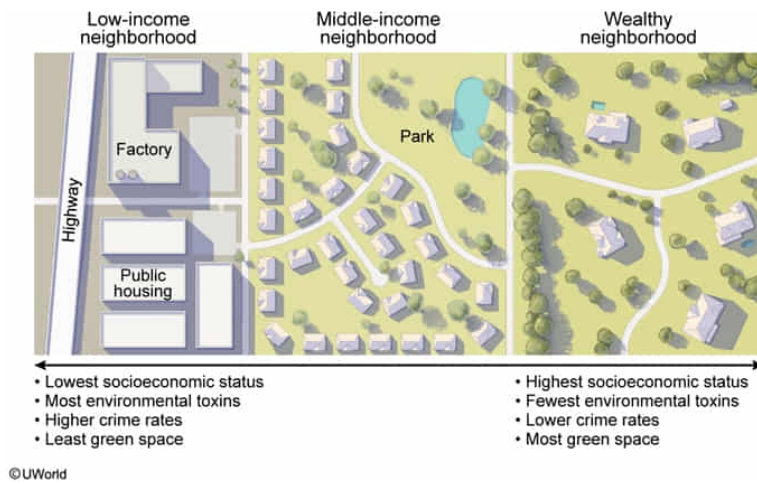
Which of the following statements is a situational attribution that is consistent with the information in the passage?

- ☐ A. Individuals born into low-income families remain impoverished because they lack motivation. [3%]
- ✔ ☒ B. Individuals from low-income neighborhoods drop out of school due to environmental stressors. [87%]
- ☐ C. Individuals who break the cycle of poverty are more resilient than those who remain impoverished. [2%]
- ☐ D. Individuals just above the poverty threshold have significantly better health than those just below it. [7%]

Correct

88% answered correctly

Explanation:



Individuals in **residentially segregated**, low-income neighborhoods (ie, high-poverty neighborhoods) are subjected to **spatial inequality**: exposure to **higher rates** of **crime**, **violence**, **pollution**, and other environmental health risks that negatively impact their health.

To **explain behavior** (our own or that of others) we make **attributions**, which are dispositional/personal (ie, based on internal characteristics such as motivation) or situational/environmental (ie, based on external factors such as the neighborhood in which one grew up).

The statement that individuals from low-income neighborhoods drop out of school due to environmental stressors is a *situational attribution* (ie, based on an external factor) consistent with the concentration of poverty in certain neighborhoods (Paragraph 2) and the association between poverty and lower graduation rates (Paragraph 4).

(Choice A) The statement that individuals remain impoverished because they lack motivation is a dispositional/personal attribution that blames poverty on characteristics of the individual.

(Choice C) The statement that individuals who break the cycle of poverty are more resilient than those who remain impoverished is a dispositional/personal attribution that implies that if one is

resilient enough (ie, a personal quality) the cycle of poverty can be broken.

(Choice D) The passage does not compare the health of individuals just above and below the poverty threshold. Furthermore, incremental increases in social strata correspond to incremental increases in health (socioeconomic gradient in health), so people just above the poverty threshold are only *marginally* healthier than those just below it.

Educational objective:

Residentially segregated, low-income neighborhoods have more crime, violence, pollution, and other environmental health risk factors (spatial inequality). Attributions are explanations for behavior and can be dispositional/personal (ie, based on internal characteristics) or situational/environmental (ie, based on external factors).

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:400086

System:

Demographics and Social Structure

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The third paragraph most directly describes the relationship between poverty and:

- ☐ A. social control. [2%]
- ✓ ☒ B. social exclusion. [96%]
- ☐ C. false consciousness.
- ☐ D. McDonaldization.

Correct

96% answered correctly

Explanation:

Social exclusion
Inability to participate: Economically (ie, as an income earner or consumer)

- Socially (ie, limited/no interaction with others in society)
- Civically (ie, community and political involvement)

Social exclusion occurs when individuals are **marginalized** to the point of being **unable** to **participate** in society **economically** (eg, earning money, purchasing goods/services), **socially** (eg, interacting with others), and **civically** (eg, voting). Social exclusion is tied to many circumstances that are stigmatized in society (eg, mental illness, poverty), although it is unclear whether social exclusion is a cause or a result of such factors.

The third paragraph, which states that poverty prevents or limits access to productive social activities, such as working, buying goods and services, community and political involvement, and engagement with social networks, most directly describes the relationship between poverty and *social exclusion*.

(Choice A) Social control is the exertion of influence by a group (eg, family, society as a whole) to ensure that the behavior of individuals conforms to that of the group. The third paragraph does not describe the relationship between poverty and social control.

(Choice C) False consciousness refers to individuals from lower classes adopting the misleading views of the upper class and therefore accepting the status quo (eg, injustice, exploitation). The third paragraph does not describe the relationship between poverty and false consciousness.

(Choice D) McDonaldization describes the process by which extreme efficiency and rationalization produce negative consequences in society (eg, reduced quality of products). The third paragraph does not describe the relationship between poverty and McDonaldization.

Educational objective:

Social exclusion is the marginalization of individuals so that they are unable to participate in society economically (through earning or spending money), socially (through interaction with others), or civically (through political or other community engagement).

Time spent:0 sec

QID:400087

Subject:

System:

Behavioral Sciences

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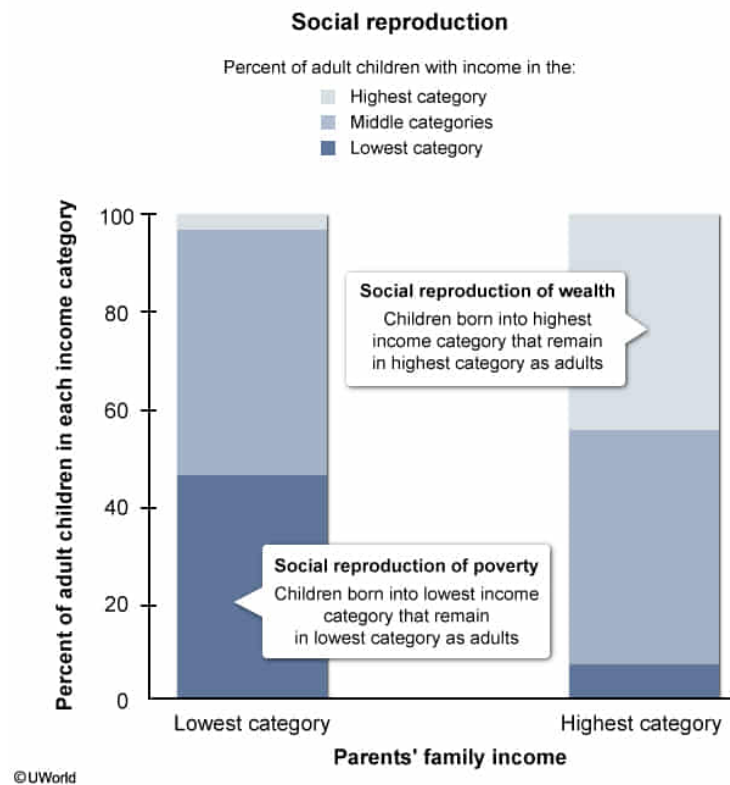
The conclusion drawn from the longitudinal study described in the final paragraph would be best supported by a follow-up study that found a:

- ✔ ☒ A. positive correlation between children's educational attainment and their parents' cultural capital. [82%]
- ☐ B. positive correlation between parents' educational attainment and their desire to help their children succeed. [4%]
- ☐ C. negative correlation between children's future earnings and their parents' economic capital. [7%]
- ☐ D. negative correlation between children's future earnings and their parents' desire to help their children succeed. [5%]

Correct

82% answered correctly

Explanation:



Social reproduction refers to the fact that **successive generations** tend to **occupy** the **same social class** (eg, children born into lower social class families tend to occupy a lower social class as adults). Social reproduction occurs because social structures (eg, tax laws) maintain and perpetuate social inequality over time.

The conclusion by the longitudinal study that the social

reproduction of poverty occurs because lower-income parents lack economic resources (ie, economic capital), social connections (ie, social capital), and knowledge about the education system (ie, cultural capital) would best be supported by a follow-up study demonstrating a positive correlation between children's educational attainment and their parents' cultural capital.

(Choice B) A positive correlation between parent's educational attainment and their desire to help their children succeed

undermines the longitudinal study's conclusion that there was no difference in terms of parents wanting to help their children succeed.

(Choice C) A negative correlation between children's future earnings and their parents' economic capital (ie, children from low-income families grow up to earn a high income) *undermines* social reproduction and does not support the longitudinal study's conclusion.

(Choice D) A negative correlation between children's future earnings and their parents' desire to help their children succeed (ie, children who earn a high income as adults had parents who had little desire to help them succeed) *undermines* the longitudinal study's conclusion that there was no difference in terms of parents wanting to help their children succeed.

Educational objective:

Social reproduction occurs when social class remains unchanged from one generation to the next (eg, children born into a lower social class tend to occupy a lower social class as adults).

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:400088

System:

Demographics and Social Structure